. Wherever negotiations may lead, I pledge my absolute commitment to Israel's security. . . .

My friend, I am convinced that we are about to embark together on a journey of historic dimensions. I know that the road will not be easy but I am determined to stay the course, confident that the world will judge our efforts as necessary to insure the permanent security of Israel. I take comfort in the fact that you've already traveled a difficult road to a successful destination of peace with Egypt. I will look to you for counsel and sustenance as we work in the cause of peace.

Ron

When Begin realized we were getting ready to go public with the proposal, he requested Ambassador Lewis to ask me to promise to notify Israeli officials at least twenty-four hours before I did. But I responded: "In view of the fact that Israeli officials have already given the media in Israel a version of some parts of my letter to the Prime Minister, I feel I have no choice but to state my views for myself openly and without delay. Therefore I have decided to address the public tonight, Sept. 1."

The Israeli cabinet wasted no time in rejecting my proposal, and Begin's reply to my letter urging serious consideration of the peace initiative was blunt. Here are excerpts from his reply:

Enclosed is a resolution of the Cabinet adopted unanimously. I can elaborate little on it, but I will take a leaf from your book and say that the government of Israel will stand by its decision with total dedication.

I agree that great events have taken place since our meeting in June, but I have a different view of what took place. . . .